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‘Irfan: A Journey into Islamic Mysticism

An Introduction for Seekers

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Book Two · Expanded edition

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An invitation

Enlighten the eyes of our hearts with the light of their looking at You to the extent that they penetrate the veils of light and reach the Source of Grandeur.
— Munajat Sha‘baniyyah¹

What is ‘irfan?

Point: The prayers we already recite ask to see God with the heart and draw near to Him. We recite this side of religion more than we practise it. That side is called ‘irfan, it means knowing God from close, it is rooted in the Quran and the Imams, and this book argues it is worth pursuing.

These words come from the Munajat Sha‘baniyyah, a prayer that many of us recite every Sha‘ban. The line asks God to light up the eyes of our hearts with the light of looking at Him, until those eyes pass through the veils of light and reach the source of His grandeur. Just before it, the prayer asks for “complete severance of my relations with everything else and total submission to You”². These are requests to see God with the heart and to be near Him. They were not written for a few saints. The Imams (‘a) gave them to ordinary believers to say.

Most of our religious life sits elsewhere. We pray, fast and pay what is due, and we try to do these things correctly, as we should. The side of religion that the Munajat describes, a heart that sees God and draws near to Him, is one we recite far more often than we practise. We say the words each year and rarely stop to ask what living them would mean.

¹Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.

²Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 165.



That side of religion has a name: *ʿirfan*. In English it is usually translated as “mysticism”, which points in the right direction but is vague. The Arabic word is more exact. It comes from the same root as *maʿrifah*, knowing, and an *ʿarif* is “someone who knows”. The knowing meant here is not information about God. It is the kind the Munajat asks for: knowing Him with the heart, from close. *ʿIrfan* is the training of the soul for that knowledge, and for the love of God that comes with it. Nothing about it is foreign to Islam. Its roots are in the Quran and in the words of the Imams, as the prayer itself shows.

This book argues that *ʿirfan* is worth every believer’s pursuit. It travels through the self and never leaves the shariʿa. It is rooted in the Quran and the Imams. It is walked by a tested and ordered method. And it ends not in withdrawal from the world but in return: to people, with God, and finally to God Himself.

Who this book is for

Point: *Any believer who practises the faith and suspects there is more to it. No background is needed, and the book is built for a busy reader.*

This book is for any believer who prays, fasts and recites the duʿas, and who has wondered whether there is more to these acts than getting them right: whether the religion has another side, beyond its rules. It assumes no knowledge of *ʿirfan*, of philosophy or of Arabic. Each chapter opens with a short line headed “Words you’ll meet”, which lists the few new terms the chapter uses, each with a brief meaning. Every term is explained again where it first appears, and all of them are gathered in a glossary at the back. The book does assume a reader who is intelligent and busy, so each chapter makes one point, proves it and stops.

How the book is built

Point: *Five parts, each answering one question in order: why, through what, whose, how, and to what end. Every chapter follows the same pattern.*

The book is in five parts. Each answers one question, and each depends on the one before.

Part One, *The Call* (Chapters 1–3), asks why a believer should bother. The Quran invites more than the minimum, the goal of *ʿirfan* is already on the



believer’s lips in the du‘as, and knowing God differs in kind from knowing about Him.

Part Two, *The Terrain* (Chapters 4–6), asks what the journey passes through and what keeps it safe. The way to God runs through the self, which is deeper than it appears, and there is no inner path outside the shari‘a.

Part Three, *The Travellers* (Chapters 7–9), asks whether ‘irfan is ours. It is native to Islam, rooted in the Quran and the Imams, carried and sometimes bent by Sufism, and held at its sober core by Shia masters.

Part Four, *The Road* (Chapters 10–15), asks how the path is walked: with a tested guide, through ordered stages, by repentance and good character, measured disciplines and love, to the loss of the false self.

Part Five, *The Return* (Chapters 16–17), asks where it ends. The friends of God return to people, with God, and every soul returns to God. ‘Irfan is making that return willingly, now.

Every chapter follows the same pattern. It opens with a verse or a prayer the reader already knows, followed by the “Words you’ll meet” line. It then argues one conclusion in short steps, each under its own heading. It ends with “Try this”, one small practice taken from the Quran, the Imams or the scholars, never invented, and with the question the next chapter answers.

Where this book comes from

Point: *The book is based on Sheikh Bahmanpour’s sixteen lectures and stays close to them. It adds the Imams’ texts and the great Shia scholars, cites every addition, and sets differing views side by side.*

The book began as a series of sixteen lectures on Islamic mysticism given by Sheikh M. S. Bahmanpour as part of a BA in Islamic Studies³. The lectures are its inspiration and the larger part of its material. Where the book reports what the Sheikh taught, it stays close to what he said.

A lecture course is spoken to a room, with the teacher there to answer questions. A book has to stand on its own, so this one also draws on the wider literature. First among these sources are the words of the Imams: Nahj al-Balagha, al-Sahifa al-Sajjadiyya and the supplications in the Mafatih. Then come the great Shia teachers of the path, from Sayyid Haydar Amuli in the fourteenth century to Mirza Jawad Maliki Tabrizi, ‘Allama Tabataba’i, Imam

³M. S. Bahmanpour, lecture slides.



Khomeini and Ayatullah Mutahhari in the twentieth. Every such addition is marked with its source, so the reader can always tell the lecture from the wider tradition.

These scholars do not always agree. They weigh differently whether a seeker needs a guide from the first step, how much solitude is wise, and how far ordinary believers can travel on the path. Where they differ, the book sets their views side by side.

What you can expect

Point: *What the book will not ask of you (powers, a sect, leaving the shari'a or your marja'), where critics are dealt with, and what a reader should know and be doing by the end.*

You will not be asked to pursue powers. Reading minds, foreseeing events and working wonders are not the aim of 'irfan. Sheikh Bahmanpour is blunt about this, and Chapter 1 shows that the wider tradition agrees with him. Nor will you be asked to join a sect or an order. Shia 'irfan has no institution of authority beside the Imam, and Chapter 9 explains how it differs from the Sufi orders and what it shares with them.

Above all, you will not be asked to step outside the shari'a. As the Sheikh puts it, the beginning of 'irfan is the shari'a. The inner path does not go around the law or rise above it: it is the law lived from the inside, with attention. Nothing in this book asks a reader to set aside the rulings of the jurists or the guidance of their marja'. Some scholars have been wary of 'irfan, and some of their concerns are serious. Chapter 8 sets out the most important of them, with the answers its defenders give.

By the end, you should be able to say what 'irfan is and is not, why it belongs to us, and what the stages and dangers of the path are. You should also have begun to practise it, with a small practice from each chapter, and to hear the prayers you already say in a different way. The epilogue gathers these practices into a plan for the first week, the first month and the first year.

1



Seeking, not powers

There are indeed signs in that for a people who reflect.

— *Quran 30:21*

There is a verse often recited at weddings, one most of us know. In Surah al-Rum, God says that He created spouses for us from among ourselves “that you may take comfort in them”, and that He ordained “affection and mercy” between husband and wife (Q 30:21). The verse ends with the words quoted above. It does not say that the sign is for everyone. It says the sign is for people who reflect. Seeing a sign, in other words, depends on something in the person looking. That something, and why it is worth developing, is the subject of this chapter.

WORDS YOU’LL MEET *‘Irfan*: knowing God from close · *ma‘rifah*: knowledge of God · *‘arif*: one who knows God · *muqarrabun*: those brought near to God · *awliya’ Allah*: the friends of God

What the minimum leaves out

Point: *The obligatory acts are enough for salvation, and that is not in dispute. What is disputed is the claim that they are the whole of religion. In Surah al-Rum the Quran asks for more than the minimum: it asks us to reflect on, know, listen to and reason about its signs.*



Let's start with two claims. The first is that a believer who prays, fasts, pays what is due and performs the hajj, who does what is *wajib* (obligatory) and avoids what is forbidden, is on the right path and can hope for *janna*. This claim is not in dispute. Sheikh Bahmanpour calls it "fair enough" for ordinary believers. Mohammad Ali Shomali makes the same point in his own terms when he describes the obligatory rules of fiqh as "the minimally necessary conditions of human perfection"⁴.

The second claim, made by some jurists and activists, is that these obligatory acts are the whole of religion, and that anything more was "made up by some mystics according to their vibes and wishes". This is the claim this book disputes. To see why, let's go back to Surah al-Rum and read on from the verse we began with.

Each of the verses that follow names one of God's signs and then says who the sign is for. The creation of the heavens and the earth, and the variety of our languages and colours, are signs "for those who know". Our sleep by night and day, and our pursuit of His bounty, are signs "for a people who listen". The lightning that brings fear and hope, and the rain that revives the earth after its death, are signs "for people who exercise their reason" (Q 30:22–24).

Four times in a row the Quran makes the same point. The signs are all around us, in marriage, in the people we meet, in sleep, in work and in the weather. But they are for those who reflect, know, listen and reason. This reflecting, knowing, listening and reasoning is what the Quran asks of us beyond the minimum.

Let's be clear about what this invitation is not. It does not lead around the law or above it. Imam Khomeini insists that a genuine seeker's devotion "is within the bounds of the Shari'ah"⁵. But the Quran is clear, in these verses and in others, that it invites us to more than the obligatory acts: to see, in the marriage and the sleep and the rain, the One whose signs they are.

Signs most people miss

Point: Most people, including devout ones, accept that the signs exist but do not perceive them. The Quran says so itself.

⁴Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 17.

⁵Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

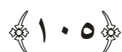


If the signs are for those who reflect, then many people do not catch them. Sheikh Bahmanpour draws this conclusion from the verses, and he does not limit it to the careless. Most pious people, he says, even those who are careful about the shari‘a, do not find the sign in these things. When we look at the variety of languages and colours, we are more likely to see a reason for division than a sign of God.

He reads the verses as a reproach: you do not reflect, you do not know, you do not listen, you do not use your reason. The Quran makes the same charge elsewhere. It asks who but God could bring light if He made the night last until the Day of Resurrection, and ends: “Will you not listen?” (Q 28:71). If we heard these signs as they are meant to be heard, he says, we would be moved by them as the prophets and the friends of God are moved.

Most of us accept that the signs exist because the Quran says they do. Accepting a sign is different from perceiving it, and one verse describes the gap.

وَكَايْنٍ مِّنْ آيَةٍ فِي السَّمَوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ يَمُرُّونَ عَلَيْهَا وَهُمْ عَنْهَا مُعْرِضُونَ



*How many a sign there is in the heavens and the earth that they pass
by while they are disregarding of it!*

Quran 12:105

‘Allama Tabataba’i explains what perceiving a sign involves. A person who sees a red light thinks of the danger it warns of, not of the colour and shape of the lamp. In the same way, the things of the world are signs, and “what the signs indicate is not this world, but the person of its Creator”⁶. Most of us see only the lamp: the rain is rain, the marriage is a marriage, and we pass by.

The signs are present, plain and addressed to us. If most people still miss them, the failure lies somewhere other than in the signs.

The fault is in the receiver

Point: We miss the signs because an inner faculty in us, the soul’s ability to perceive, is not working. It exists and is only rusted, so it can be repaired. ‘Irfan is that repair.

⁶Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, pp. 6–7.



The Quran says where the failure lies. It speaks of people who have every faculty and use none of them.

وَلَقَدْ ذَرَأْنَا لِجَهَنَّمَ كَثِيرًا مِّنَ الْجِنِّ وَالْإِنسِ لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ بَّ لَا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا
وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أُذُنٌ لَا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَا أُولَٰئِكَ
كَالْأَنْعَامِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ أُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْغَافِلُونَ ﴿١٧٩﴾

Certainly We have winnowed out for hell many of the jinn and humans: they have hearts with which they do not understand, they have eyes with which they do not see, they have ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle; indeed, they are more astray. It is they who are the heedless.

Quran 7:179

Cattle see and hear perfectly well, so the comparison cannot be about the senses. Sheikh Bahmanpour reads it as being about what lies behind them. Eyes and ears take in the surface of things. Inside a human being there should be something that turns what they take in into understanding: an inner faculty that animals lack and that we have. In most of us, he says, it is not working. Someone who rejects faith may protest that he sees in more detail than any believer. The Quran's answer is that he sees, but does not understand.

Sheikh Bahmanpour compares this faculty to a machine. The ear catches the sound, but "there is something inside which doesn't catch it. There is a machine inside which is rust." That machine is the soul. It does not work, and it has to be repaired before it can catch the signals of God. For him this is the whole subject in one sentence: "Mysticism is all about making one's soul to hear, to see and to reflect." The rest of this book, the stages, the disciplines and the dangers, is about how that repair is done. He does not pretend it is easy: "It needs lots of training."

Two things follow from putting the fault here. The first is that the problem is not a shortage of evidence. God is not withholding signs from us; we are failing to receive them. The second is that the problem can be solved, because a faculty that exists but has rusted can be repaired, where one that is absent cannot. The *Kernel of the Kernels*, a record of 'Allama Tabataba'i's early lectures on the path, opens by saying that the pull towards the unseen is "part



of the innate instincts of the human being”⁷. The longing, and the faculty it belongs to, are part of how we are made.

Repair is only the start. Once the inner faculty begins to work, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, the real journey begins, and it does not end: the path “has a beginning and no end”.

Some do see

Point: *The Quran describes believers in whom this faculty works: hearts that tremble at God’s mention, those who know, the friends of God. These are the people the tradition calls the ‘urafa’.*

If the faculty can be repaired, there should be people in whom it works, and the Quran describes them more than once. Sheikh Bahmanpour divides people into two groups: those whose souls work and those whose souls do not. He calls the first group the ‘urafa’, the plural of ‘arif. He sets the prophets and Imams (‘a) aside as a class of their own and looks at ordinary believers who see more than the rest.

The first description is in Surah al-Anfal.

إِنَّمَا الْمُؤْمِنُونَ الَّذِينَ إِذَا ذُكِرَ اللَّهُ وَجِلَتْ قُلُوبُهُمْ وَإِذَا تُلِيَتْ عَلَيْهِمْ آيَاتُهُ زَادَتْهُمْ إِيمَانًا وَعَلَىٰ رَبِّهِمْ يَتَوَكَّلُونَ ﴿٢﴾

The faithful are only those whose hearts tremble [with awe] when Allah is mentioned, and when His signs are recited to them, they increase their faith, and who put their trust in their Lord, ...

Quran 8:2

A heart trembles only at the mention of someone it has some experience of. A name means little to someone who does not know whom it names. The believers of this verse, then, are believers who know Allah. The opening of Surah al-Mu’minun describes the same people at prayer: “those who are humble in their prayers” (Q 23:2). The Arabic word, *khashi‘*, means more than humble. It describes someone in whom something gives way when they stand before God, because of what they have experienced of Him.

⁷‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 4.



Another verse goes higher. God bears witness that there is no god except Him, “and [so do] the angels and those who possess knowledge” (Q 3:18). Sheikh Bahmanpour reads “those who possess knowledge” as another name for the ‘urafa’. Every Muslim knows that there is no god but Allah, but our knowledge of *tawhid*, God’s oneness, is not the knowledge of those who witness it. Tawhid is simple to say and hard to grasp, and he holds that the intellect alone cannot reach its depths; only the awakened soul can.

Surah Fatir adds: “Only those of Allah’s servants having knowledge fear Him” (Q 35:28). Most of us fear Allah’s punishment. The people of this verse fear Him with a fear that is not about punishment at all. Surah Yunus gives them a second name, which the lectures treat as the same people: the *awliya’ Allah*, the friends of God (Q 10:62).

Imam ‘Ali (‘a) describes what these people see that others miss.

*God’s special devotees are those who perceive the world’s reality when others are deceived by her appearance. They occupy themselves with what is coming when others occupy themselves with the present.*⁸

Other people look at the surface of the world; the friends of God look at what lies inside it. Sheikh Bahmanpour is careful about what this means. There is nothing wrong, in the shari’a, with being rich. The trouble is being occupied with it. The friends of God have families, friends and a place in society, as we do. But they do not think about themselves; they think about God, and in their hearts they are cut off from everything else.

What they are given, and why it is open to you

Point: *The Quran promises these people nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief. It opens their rank to any believer who obeys and acts righteously. That is the case for pursuing ‘irfan.*

The Quran also tells us what these people receive, and whether the rest of us can join them.

The reward. The first gift is nearness. Surah al-Waqi’a sorts people on the Last Day, and at the top it places “the Foremost Ones”, who “are the ones brought near [to Allah]” (Q 56:10–11). The Arabic is *muqarrabun*. God is not far from anyone, Sheikh Bahmanpour points out, so being brought near means that a veil between the person and God has been removed, and they

⁸Imam ‘Ali, *Nahj al-Balagha* (trans. Qutbuddin), 3.403.



understand far more. The second gift is a different kind of life. To whoever acts righteously, man or woman, while having faith, God promises: “We shall revive him with a good life” (Q 16:97). This good life, *hayat tayyiba*, is in Sheikh Bahmanpour’s reading a clean life: its people live in the world without being soiled by it, and rise above the worries that occupy everyone else. It “is of course what mystics are after”, he says. The third gift is peace.

أَلَا إِنَّ أَوْلِيَاءَ اللَّهِ لَا خَوْفٌ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا هُمْ يَحْزَنُونَ ﴿٦٢﴾

Look! The friends of Allah will indeed have no fear nor will they grieve

Quran 10:62

For the muqarrabun, Sheikh Bahmanpour says, “the whole terms and conditions are different”. They are given Paradise in this world, and in the next they are after something more.

The access. None of this would matter to an ordinary reader if it were reserved for prophets. Surah al-Nisa’ answers the question.

وَمَنْ يُطِيعِ اللَّهَ وَالرَّسُولَ فَأُولَٰئِكَ مَعَ الَّذِينَ أَنْعَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَيْهِمْ مِنَ النَّبِيِّينَ وَالصِّدِّيقِينَ وَالشُّهَدَاءِ وَالصَّالِحِينَ وَحَسُنَ أُولَٰئِكَ رَفِيقًا ﴿٦٩﴾

Whoever obeys Allah and the Apostle—they are with those whom Allah has blessed, including the prophets and the truthful, the martyrs and the righteous, and excellent companions are they!

Quran 4:69

Sheikh Bahmanpour reads this verse as naming four ranks of those God has blessed: the prophets; the truthful (*siddiqin*); the *shuhada’*, which the translation used here renders “martyrs” and which he takes as “the witnesses”; and the righteous (*salihin*). The first three ranks, he says, are beyond us. The fourth is a doorway. The salihin are those able to receive this favour, and it is from among them that God chooses the truthful and the prophets. The way in is righteous action, as the verse on the good life also says.

In his words, “ordinary people also can enter into the realm of muqarrabun”. It is difficult, he says, but it is open, because we are made for it. He puts it bluntly: we call ourselves human beings, but “we are not yet human beings”. We begin with the potential to become human in the full sense that



the prophets are. He means this as a statement of what we were made for: “A human being has the capacity to become a friend of God. Allah has created us at this strength and He wants us to reach that strength.”

Hence the case for pursuing it. The Quran invites more than the minimum, and what stands in the way is a faculty in us that can be repaired. On the other side of that repair lie nearness to God, a good life, and freedom from fear and grief, in a rank the Quran opens to any believer who obeys God and the Prophet and acts righteously.

For what? Not powers

Point: *Training the soul can aim at powers or at God. Sheikh Bahmanpour calls powers sought this way shirk. Tabataba'i, Khomeini and Mutahhari each agree in their own way: the aim of 'irfan is God alone.*

Pursuing this means training the soul, and soul-training is not unique to Islam. People take up the inner life for different reasons. Some train the soul to gain power: to be in two places at once, to see the future or the past, to explore the hidden world of the soul so as to master it. Sheikh Bahmanpour says this kind of mysticism must be told apart from the real thing, because Islamic mysticism is about catching the signs of Allah, becoming sensitive to them and learning to hear and see.

He ended his first class more strongly. 'Irfan “is not about any type of power or empowering the soul” to work *karamat* and *mu'jizat*, the wonders of the saints and the miracles of the prophets. Then: “These are shirk.” *Shirk*, associating partners with God, is the gravest charge in Islam. [QUERY: L01 ¶32, “These are shirk”: does “these” mean seeking *karamat* and *mu'jizat*, or the powers themselves? Confirm with the lecturer.]

The great teachers of the Shia tradition make closely related points, each in his own words. 'Allama Tabataba'i tells the traveller that he “has no right to seek occult experiences and miraculous qualities”, nor to perform austerities or recite invocations to gain powers such as crossing great distances in a moment or reading the thoughts of others. Whoever does so “does not move on the path of the Beloved’s pleasure and his worship is not for the sake of God”. It is his own self that he worships, “though he may not admit it by word of mouth”⁹.

⁹Allama Tabataba'i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihriani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara'i), pp. 28–29.



◆ WHO'S WHO: ‘ALLAMA TABATABA’I

Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Tabataba’i is best known as the author of *al-Mizan*, a commentary on the Quran in twenty volumes¹⁰. His student Sayyid Muhammad Husayn Husayni Tihrani describes him as having flown “with the two wings of knowledge and action”. He travelled the path in both philosophy and gnosis under the guidance of the gnostic Mirza ‘Ali Aqa Qadi, and after years of philosophical argument he “came to settle down at the sacred threshold of the Qur’an”¹¹. *Kernel of the Kernels* (*Lubb al-Lubab*) is Tihrani’s record of the lectures on ethics and gnosis that Tabataba’i gave to students in Qum in 1949–50¹². He also wrote the preface to *Light Within Me*¹³, from which several quotations in this chapter come.

Imam Khomeini reports the test his teacher Ayatullah Shahabadi used: the measure of true spiritual effort is how much selfishness is in it. If a traveller’s “spiritual exercises are meant for acquiring powers for worldly ends, his efforts are rendered invalid”¹⁴. Murtada Mutahhari uses the same word as Sheikh Bahmanpour. The ‘urafa’, he writes, consider it “a kind of shirk (polytheism) for one’s goal in life and particularly in worship to be something other than God Himself”. He recalls the words of Imam ‘Ali (‘a): “My God, I do not worship You in fear of Your Fire, nor in desire for Your Paradise, but I find You worthy of worship so I worship You”¹⁵.

The scholars differ in emphasis but agree that powers are not the aim. Sheikh Bahmanpour calls such powers shirk, and Mutahhari’s words show why seeking them would be: the goal has become something other than God. ‘Allama Tabataba’i, discussing how to judge whether a spiritual teacher is genuine, speaks of what may appear on the road. Reading minds or foretelling the future, he says, “becomes possible at the beginning of spiritual vision”, but “the stage of proximity to Allah is far away from this stage”, and such things “are not a sign of anybody’s being a favorite of Allah”¹⁶. For him the feats are beside the point, something a student should look past when deciding whom to trust.

¹⁰ Mohammad Ali Shomali, *Self-Knowledge*, p. 30.

¹¹ ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 8.

¹² ‘Allama Tabataba’i and S. M. H. Husayni Tihrani, *Kernel of the Kernels* (trans. Qara’i), p. 9.

¹³ Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.

¹⁴ Imam Khomeini, *Forty Hadith*, p. 61.

¹⁵ Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 44.

¹⁶ Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 101.



Seeking, and nothing else

Point: *‘Irfan is seeking God, the knowledge and love of Him, and nothing else. The chapter’s conclusion follows: ‘irfan is worth pursuing, as the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer and sought for God alone.*

With powers set aside, what remains is the definition Sheikh Bahmanpour gave at the end of his first class: ‘irfan “is actually seeking and nothing else”. It seeks two things: *ma‘rifah*, the knowledge of God, and the love of God. These, he says, are the two things by which the friends of God fly: a knowledge that keeps increasing and a love that is never quenched.

ع WORD STUDY: ‘IRFAN AND MA‘RIFAH

‘Irfan, *ma‘rifah*, *‘arif* and its plural *‘urafa’* belong to one family of words about knowing. An *‘arif*, as Sheikh Bahmanpour puts it, is “someone who knows”. “Mystic” is used of Christians, Hindus and Buddhists alike; *‘arif* is the Islamic word, and it makes a precise claim. Murtada Mutahhari draws the line. The philosopher wants a correct picture of the world in his mind. The *‘arif* “wishes to reach the very kernel and reality of existence, God, to become connected to it and witness it”¹⁷. *Lantern of the Path*, attributed to Imam al-Sadiq (‘a), puts it in one line: “There is no way to Allah except via knowledge”¹⁸. What kind of knowledge that is, and how it differs from what we learn from books, is the subject of Chapter 3.

‘Allama Tabataba’i’s definition says the same: “The real gnostic is he who worships Allah not, because he hopes for any reward or is afraid of any punishment, but only because he knows Him and loves Him”¹⁹.

‘Irfan is therefore worth pursuing: it is the training of the soul to perceive and love God, open to every believer, and sought for God alone.

If the aim is to know and love God, what does that longing sound like?

► TRY THIS

Sheikh Bahmanpour built his first lesson on the four signs of Surah al-Rum. For one week, read Q 30:21–24 slowly once a day. After each verse, ask yourself

¹⁷Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 12.

¹⁸*Lantern of the Path* (Misbah al-Shari’a), p. 9.

¹⁹Mutahhari, Tabataba’i and Khomeini, *Light Within Me*, p. 4.



what he found in its ending: whether you reflect, whether you know, whether you listen and whether you use your reason. Then, at some point in the day, notice one of the four signs where it occurs in your life: the affection in your home, the languages and colours of the people you meet, your own sleep and the work that earns your living, or the rain.